

General Aptitude Questions for Humanities / Arts

Political Science, International Relations and Public Policy

A note to students: This assessment is not a test of how much you have memorised. It is designed to understand how you think about political ideas, public life, governance, and global affairs. There are no trick questions. Read each question carefully, think it through, and choose the answer that makes the most sense to you. Students who follow current events, enjoy debating public issues, or find themselves curious about how governments and societies work tend to find this assessment engaging. Take your time and enjoy it.

Section 1: Indian Political System and Constitution

Q1. A newly independent country is deciding how to organise its government. Several leaders argue that a constitution must be written before the first elections are held. What is the strongest argument in favour of this approach?

- A) It allows the founding leaders to set permanent rules before rivals can challenge them
- B) It establishes a shared framework of governance that applies equally to everyone, including those who hold power
- C) It signals to foreign countries that the new nation is stable enough for investment
- D) It ensures that only qualified and experienced people can stand for election

Q2. A sitting government passes a new law that many citizens believe violates their fundamental rights. In a functioning democracy, which institution is best placed to examine whether this law is constitutionally valid?

- A) The Prime Minister's office, since the executive holds the highest authority in day-to-day governance
- B) The Parliament, since it created the law and understands the intent behind it

C) An independent judiciary, since it can review laws against constitutional standards without political pressure

D) The media, since it most directly represents public opinion

Q3. A state government and the central government are in a serious disagreement about which level of government has the authority to make decisions on a particular issue. This kind of dispute is most characteristic of which feature of India's political system?

A) Parliamentary democracy

B) Universal adult franchise

C) Judicial review

D) Federalism

Q4. In a democracy, why are regular elections considered essential rather than something that can be postponed when things are going well?

A) They give political parties an opportunity to raise public awareness about their work

B) They allow citizens to hold their representatives accountable and choose who governs them

C) They make the administrative system run more efficiently

D) They ensure that experienced people remain in positions of authority

Q5. A government argues that during a national emergency, certain fundamental rights may need to be temporarily suspended to maintain order. What is the most important democratic concern this situation raises?

A) Whether the suspension will negatively affect the country's economic growth

B) Whether there are strong enough checks on how and when such emergency powers can be used

C) Whether citizens will find alternative ways to express themselves during the emergency

D) Whether other countries will view the decision as legitimate

Section 2: Political Thinking and Public Policy

Q6. A government is debating whether to introduce reservations in government jobs for historically disadvantaged communities. Supporters say it promotes equality. Critics say it limits individual freedom of opportunity. What kind of political tension does this debate represent?

A) The tension between nationalism and globalism

B) The tension between democracy and authoritarianism

C) The tension between liberty and equality

D) The tension between federalism and centralisation

Q7. A country applies the same prison sentence to everyone convicted of stealing food, regardless of whether they stole out of hunger or out of greed. A legal scholar argues this is "formally fair but substantively unjust." What does the scholar most likely mean?

A) The law is too lenient and should be made much stricter across the board

B) Applying identical rules without considering people's circumstances can still produce outcomes that are genuinely unfair

C) Wealthier people should always receive harsher punishments than poorer people

D) The criminal justice system should not punish minor crimes at all

Q8. A city government is trying to reduce traffic congestion. It considers two options: building more roads or introducing a fee on vehicles entering the city centre during peak hours. What makes the second option a good example of policy thinking?

- A) It involves collecting additional revenue from citizens
- B) It tries to change people's behaviour through incentives rather than simply expanding infrastructure
- C) It is cheaper to implement than building new roads
- D) It requires approval from a higher level of government

Q9. A government passes a law guaranteeing free education for all children. Several years later, studies show that children from the poorest families are still not attending school regularly. What does this situation most clearly reveal about governance?

- A) That the law was poorly written and needs to be replaced immediately
- B) That passing a law is not sufficient on its own without implementation, monitoring, and addressing barriers on the ground
- C) That education is simply not a priority for most low-income families
- D) That the government should reduce its spending on education programmes

Q10. A city plans to demolish an informal settlement to build a public hospital. The residents argue their right to housing is being violated. The government argues the hospital will benefit a far greater number of people. What is the central political dilemma in this situation?

- A) Whether hospitals are more socially important than housing
- B) Whether individual rights can be overridden for collective benefit, and what safeguards should be in place when that happens
- C) Whether urban infrastructure should take priority over rural development
- D) Whether the government has allocated enough money for both the hospital and alternative housing

Section 3: International Relations and Global Affairs

Q11. The United Nations was established after the Second World War. What was the primary reason the international community believed such an organisation was necessary?

- A) To create a world government with the authority to overrule national decisions
- B) To give nations a platform for dialogue, dispute resolution, and preventing armed conflict
- C) To allow wealthy countries to coordinate their economic and trade policies
- D) To enforce a single set of cultural and social norms across all member states

Q12. Two neighbouring countries have a long-standing border dispute. Both have large militaries, but instead of escalating, they agree to bilateral talks facilitated by a neutral third country. Why is this approach generally preferred in international relations?

- A) Military action is always more expensive and always takes longer to produce results
- B) Diplomatic solutions are more likely to produce outcomes both sides can accept and maintain over time
- C) International law makes military action illegal under all circumstances
- D) Third-party mediators are given the legal authority to impose binding decisions on both sides

Q13. Scientists broadly agree that climate change requires global cooperation. Yet countries regularly struggle to reach meaningful agreements. What is the most significant structural challenge in these negotiations?

- A) Most governments privately do not believe that climate change is real
- B) Countries at different levels of economic development have different capacities and different historical responsibilities, making consensus genuinely difficult

C) International organisations like the UN are too powerful and prevent countries from acting in their own interest

D) Climate change is fundamentally a scientific and technical problem, not a political one

Q14. India has historically avoided formally aligning itself with any major military bloc. What is the primary advantage of this approach for a country in India's position?

A) It allows India to avoid all international legal and diplomatic obligations

B) It gives India the flexibility to build relationships with a wide range of countries based on its own national interests

C) It guarantees that India will never be drawn into international conflicts of any kind

D) It prevents India from joining major international organisations and trade bodies

Q15. A developing country joins a global free trade agreement. Economists project that the agreement will increase the country's overall national income. However, some domestic industries may struggle to compete with cheaper imports, and certain workers may lose their jobs. What does this situation most clearly illustrate about globalisation?

A) That free trade is fundamentally harmful to all developing countries

B) That the benefits and costs of globalisation are often distributed unevenly across different groups within the same country

C) That developing countries should always prioritise domestic production over international trade

D) That all trade agreements are designed primarily to favour wealthy and powerful nations

Section 4: Analytical and Political Reasoning

Q16. A newly elected government extends its own term in office by two years without holding elections, citing ongoing national security concerns. A political analyst describes this as a serious threat to democratic norms. What is the strongest basis for this concern?

A) The government should have strengthened the defence budget before making any such decision

B) Regular elections are the core mechanism through which democratic accountability works, and bypassing them undermines legitimate authority regardless of the reason given

C) National security concerns should never have any influence on political decisions in a democracy

D) Only the courts should have the authority to extend a government's term in exceptional circumstances

Q17. A government introduces free public transport across a major city. Supporters argue it reduces pollution and increases access for lower-income citizens. Critics argue it is fiscally unsustainable and will lead to overcrowding. Which of the following represents the most balanced way to evaluate this policy?

A) Judge it purely by whether it reduces the government's annual budget deficit

B) Assess both the intended social benefits and the practical costs, including who gains and who bears the burden

C) Support it only if every single citizen switches to using public transport

D) Reject it on the grounds that any policy involving significant public expenditure is poor governance

Q18. A politician argues: "Our country has always been a democracy, so we do not need any new laws to protect democratic rights." What is the most significant weakness in this argument?

A) The politician is probably misrepresenting the country's actual political history

- B) A democratic tradition from the past does not guarantee that democratic institutions are functioning well today or that they cannot gradually be weakened
- C) New laws are by definition always better than existing ones
- D) Rights and democratic protections are only relevant concerns in authoritarian countries

Q19. A government must allocate a limited budget and is choosing between two options: immediate poverty relief programmes that help people right now, or long-term investments in roads, schools, and public health infrastructure. Both are genuinely important. What does this dilemma most fundamentally reflect about governance?

- A) That governments should avoid making financial decisions without approval from international institutions
- B) That resource constraints force governments to make difficult choices between short-term needs and long-term development
- C) That poverty reduction and infrastructure building are essentially unrelated policy areas
- D) That democratic governments are structurally less efficient than authoritarian ones when it comes to managing public resources

Q20. Three commentators are discussing a new law that allows the government to monitor citizens' online communications.

Commentator A says: "This law will make citizens safer by helping prevent crime and terrorism."

Commentator B says: "This law gives the government far too much power to monitor the private lives of ordinary citizens."

Commentator C says: "The real impact of this law depends entirely on how it is implemented and whether there is genuine independent oversight of how it is used."

Which commentator is demonstrating the most sophisticated political reasoning?

- A) Commentator A, because public safety must always come before other considerations
- B) Commentator B, because civil liberties should never be compromised under any circumstances
- C) Commentator C, because the position acknowledges real trade-offs and recognises that institutional safeguards determine whether a law serves the public good
- D) All three positions are equally valid and cannot meaningfully be compared

Answer Key and Explanations

Question	Correct Answer
Q1	B
Q2	C
Q3	D
Q4	B
Q5	B
Q6	C
Q7	B
Q8	B
Q9	B
Q10	B
Q11	B

Q12	B
Q13	B
Q14	B
Q15	B
Q16	B
Q17	B
Q18	B
Q19	B
Q20	C

Q1. Answer: B A constitution creates a shared framework that governs how power is exercised and limits arbitrary authority. Its defining feature is that it applies to everyone equally, including those in power.

Q2. Answer: C An independent judiciary acts as a check on both the legislature and the executive by reviewing whether laws conform to the constitution. Its independence from political pressure is what makes this role meaningful.

Q3. Answer: D Federalism divides governing authority between central and state governments. Disputes over which level of government has jurisdiction over a given issue are a natural and recurring feature of federal systems.

Q4. Answer: B Regular elections are the primary mechanism through which citizens exercise their right to hold governments accountable. Without this mechanism, the relationship between the governed and those who govern breaks down.

Q5. Answer: B Emergency powers exist in many constitutional frameworks, but democracies require strong safeguards to prevent such powers from being misused, extended beyond genuine necessity, or used to justify permanent erosion of rights.

Q6. Answer: C Reservations are a classic illustration of the tension between individual liberty, meaning freedom of opportunity without state intervention, and equality, meaning using state action to correct historical disadvantage.

Q7. Answer: B Formal fairness means applying the same rules to everyone. Substantive justice asks whether those equal rules actually produce fair outcomes, especially when the people they apply to are in very different circumstances.

Q8. Answer: B Policy thinking involves using instruments like incentives, taxes, and regulations to shape behaviour and achieve social goals. A congestion fee does this by making driving more costly and therefore encouraging alternatives.

Q9. Answer: B Effective governance requires more than legislation. Laws must be accompanied by implementation capacity, monitoring systems, and attention to the practical and social barriers that prevent people from accessing their entitlements.

Q10. Answer: B This is a foundational dilemma in political philosophy and governance, involving the question of when and under what conditions the rights of individuals can be overridden in the name of the collective good, and what protections should exist when that happens.

Q11. Answer: B The UN was created primarily to give nations a forum for dialogue, collective security, and conflict prevention. It was a direct response to the catastrophic consequences of two world wars fought without such a structure.

Q12. Answer: B Military resolution of disputes can end immediate confrontations but rarely addresses underlying causes. Diplomatic solutions, especially with neutral facilitation, are more likely to produce outcomes both parties can accept and sustain.

Q13. Answer: B The central structural tension in climate negotiations is between nations at different stages of development. Developed nations have contributed more to historical emissions while developing nations argue they should not sacrifice economic growth to fix a problem they did not primarily cause.

Q14. Answer: B A policy of strategic autonomy allows India to engage with multiple global powers without being bound by the obligations that come with

formal military alliances. This flexibility has been a consistent thread in Indian foreign policy since independence.

Q15. Answer: B Globalisation can increase overall national wealth, but its benefits and costs are rarely distributed evenly. Workers in sectors exposed to import competition may lose out even as other parts of the economy grow. This uneven distribution is one of the central political challenges of globalisation.

Q16. Answer: B Regular elections are not just administrative events. They are the mechanism through which governments derive their legitimate authority to govern. Bypassing them, regardless of the justification offered, severs this connection between authority and accountability.

Q17. Answer: B Sound policy evaluation requires looking at multiple dimensions simultaneously, including intended social goals, fiscal costs, distributional effects, and practical implementation. Focusing on only one dimension gives an incomplete and often misleading picture.

Q18. Answer: B Democratic institutions and norms can weaken gradually even in countries with long democratic traditions. A history of democracy is not a permanent guarantee. Active legal and institutional maintenance is required to sustain it.

Q19. Answer: B Resource constraints are a constant reality in governance. The trade-off between immediate relief and long-term investment is not a failure of policy thinking but a central and unavoidable challenge that policymakers in every country must navigate.

Q20. Answer: C Commentator C demonstrates the most analytically mature position by moving beyond a simple binary framing. Recognising that the real-world impact of a policy depends on implementation quality and the presence of institutional checks reflects a genuinely sophisticated understanding of how governance works.